

Angola

An Africa–Europe Cultural Co-Production · Overview

GOETHE-INSTITUT AFRICA–EUROPE PARTNERSHIPS FOR CULTURE · 2026

Angola is internationally legible through two stories — the 1975–2002 civil war and the oil-and-diamond economy that made Luanda one of the world’s most expensive cities. Both are loud; both crowd out the quieter country. INLAND asks one question across every lead: what survived? What persists in specific families, villages and practices that has been absorbed by neither the colonial inheritance, the Catholic mission, the long war, nor the petro-modernisation of the coast — and can still be witnessed and photographed today.

We focus on endangered knowledge systems and under-documented living practices surviving despite rupture, standardisation and generational drift — from the UNESCO-listed but fragile sona sand-writing of the Lunda-Chokwe to the Kianda sea-offerings of Luanda’s original fishing people. The civil war is context, never the lens; the state is never cast as villain. Every storyline centres a custodian, a place, and a practice that can still be witnessed.

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The 12 Storylines

The Men Who Write in Sand

Sona, the Lunda-Chokwe Script

THE STORY

In the cleaned, dotted sand of the Lunda, elder masters called akwa kuta sona draw a single unbroken geometric line that holds a proverb or a cosmology — a tradition perhaps over two thousand years old. UNESCO inscribed it as Intangible Cultural Heritage in December 2023.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows one master through a night of storytelling around Saurimo and Dundo, with access via Lueji A’Nkonde University — documenting a writing-in-sand recognised at the very moment it is most fragile. The defining image of the edition.

Places: Saurimo · Dundo · Lunda · Sources: UNESCO ICH 2023; Lusona (Wikipedia); FLM Journal

The Fire That Stays Lit

The Ovimbundu Ondjango

THE STORY

The ondjango council house is built around a fire kept permanently alight — a sign of the soba’s lineage and continuity. Bailundo (Huambo) is the centre of Angola’s largest people; King Ekuikui VI, enthroned by the ombala elders in 2021, is a living authority.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND sits in on a council night and traces the wood the young bring to feed the fire — a living institution of speech and consensus, not a museum piece. The hearth is the edition’s emblem.

Places: Bailundo · Huambo · Sources: Bailundo (Wikipedia); UNILAB; Africanews

Hair, Herd and Drought

The Mwila and the Mucubal

THE STORY

On the Huíla plateau and in Namibe, the Mwila wear ochre nontombi plaits and the Mucubal the ompota headdress — hairstyles that read as a language of life-stage and mourning. The cattle economy is the base of identity, and its herd-healing knowledge is endangered.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND walks a leg of the dry-season transhumance and documents a hairstyle being made and read — a culture worn on the body and carried in the herd, under climate pressure. Custodian-led, never the tourist ‘tribal portrait’.

Places: Huíla plateau · Namibe · Sources: Minority Rights Group; PMC ethnoveterinary study 2024

Offerings to Kianda

The Festa da Ilha

THE STORY

Every second Friday of November the Axiluanda — Luanda's original fishing people, whose name is the city's own — cast offerings into the sea to Kianda, the water spirit who protects fishermen, as a luxury waterfront pushes them off their own sandbar.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND shoots the full midnight feast and portraits the fishers, pairing the rite with the redevelopment squeezing it out — two relationships to the same sea. The project's signature recurring scene.

Places: Ilha de Luanda · Sources: Kianda (Wikipedia); Ilha de Luanda (Wikipedia)

The Mask That Dances a Woman

Mukanda and Mwana Pwo

THE STORY

The world's museums are full of Chokwe masks; the rite that animates them is barely filmed. During mukanda, the months-long boys' initiation camp, a male dancer becomes mwana pwo — an idealised female ancestor — for the mothers separated from their sons.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND documents a mwana pwo performance and a carver, building a diptych of the museum vitrine against the dust of the camp. Discretion and consent around the seclusion itself.

Places: Lunda · Moxico · Dundo Museum · Sources: Chokwe people (Wikipedia); High Museum / DIA

The Coffee That Went Wild

Amboim Robusta

THE STORY

Angola was the world's third-largest coffee producer until the war turned plantations into wild bush. Now families harvest from trees their grandparents planted, and the EU/AFD-financed Mukafe scheme is replanting Amboim's prized robusta in Kwanza Sul.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows one family through a harvest — the abandoned colonial roça now forest, the replant beside it — a story of return on land the war made wild. The family is named in the field.

Places: Amboim · Gabela · Kwanza Sul · Uíge · Sources: Perfect Daily Grind; STiR; Coffee in Angola (Wikipedia)

The Council That Outlived the King

The Lumbu of Mbanza Kongo

THE STORY

At Mbanza Kongo, UNESCO-listed capital of the old Kongo kingdom, there has been no king for decades — yet the lumbu, a tribunal of twenty-one elders that advised the throne for over five hundred years, still meets.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND attends a council sitting and maps the sacred topography of a city where the royal past lies underfoot — an institution that outlived the institution it served.

Places: Mbanza Kongo · Zaire · Sources: UNESCO WHC 2017; Met Museum (Kongo)

Njinga’s Footprints

The Black Rocks of Pungo Andongo

THE STORY

At the black monoliths of Pungo Andongo — the Ndongo capital and Queen Njinga’s 17th-century stronghold against the Portuguese — footprints worn into the rock are venerated locally as the queen’s own.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND shoots the footprints as a living place of veneration and the rocks as refuge — national memory made physical, a 400-year-old resistance still touched by hand.

Places: Pungo Andongo · Malanje · Sources: Black Rocks at Pungo Andongo (Wikipedia); Atlas Obscura

Those Who Ate the Ox

Efundula in Cunene

THE STORY

The efundula female initiation marks a girl’s passage to womanhood among the Kwanyama and Handa of Cunene — historically the symbolic ‘eating of the ox’ — surviving in tension with the school and the state.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows the cycle with the community’s lead and the voices of young mothers caught between the rite and schooling — continuity and its costs, consent-led, never staged.

Places: Cunene · southern Huíla · Sources: Academia.edu; UCP study (Cunene)

Salt and the Long Boats

Baía Farta

THE STORY

In one Benguela bay, two squeezed coastal trades: solar salt evaporated in the pans that named the beach, and an artisanal fishing economy of tens of thousands — both pressed by industrial trawling and packaged substitutes.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND shoots a salt-raking day and a fishing dawn at the Casa dos Pescadores Artesanais — the food infrastructure of the coast, still made by hand.

Places: Baía Farta · Benguela · Sources: Journey Gourmet; trackstick; DLIST Benguela

Clay and Fibre

Women Potters and Weavers

THE STORY

Coil pottery and sisal and palm basketry, made by methods passed down generations across the highlands and east, now half-commercialised for an urban market — the domestic vessels of Angolan household life, and the women who still make them.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND portraits one named maker through a full firing or weaving and the market stall beyond — women's craft as both heritage and household economy.

Places: Huambo · Bié · Moxico · Sources: African Sahara; Design Milk

The Most Expensive City and the Musseque

Two Relationships to One Shore

THE STORY

Luanda's oil-built towers stand a few hundred metres from self-built musseques and the kitanda markets that feed the city — and from the sandbar where families still fish and pray to Kianda.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND anchors the petro-city in one human — an Ilha fisher, a market woman — so the contradiction is portrait, not abstraction: two economies sharing one shore.

Places: Luanda · Ilha de Luanda · Sources: Ilha de Luanda (Wikipedia); INLAND field framing

Production Tracks

The Lunda Cluster

STORIES 01 + 05

The Planalto Cluster

STORIES 02 + 06 + 11

South & Coast

STORIES 03 + 09 + 10

The eastern art heartland: the sona sand-writing masters around Saurimo and Dundo, and the mukanda / mwana pwo mask rite. One deployment, access via Lueji A’Nkonde University and the Dundo Museum.

Geography: Saurimo → Dundo (Lunda) → Moxico
Season: Dry-season camps (≈May–Sep)
2 stories, 1 field base

The central highlands: the ondjango council fire at Bailundo (King Ekuikui VI’s court), the Amboim robusta revival in Kwanza Sul, and highland potters and weavers. Governance, return and craft.

Geography: Bailundo (Huambo) → Amboim (Kwanza Sul)
Season: Coffee harvest (≈May–Aug)
3 stories, 1 deployment

Mwila and Mucubal pastoral knowledge on the Huíla plateau and Namibe, the efundula female initiation in Cunene (consent-led), and salt and artisanal fishing at Baía Farta. Body, herd and sea.

Geography: Lubango → Cunene → Benguela coast
Season: Dry-season transhumance
3 stories, seasonal windows

The Partnership

EUROPEAN PARTNER

INLAND — yearly publication (Italy / EU). Editorial, photography and publishing; presentation of the work in Europe.

AFRICAN PARTNER

An Angolan cultural organisation (lead candidate: Lueji A’Nkonde University, Lunda Norte — which coordinated the sona UNESCO nomination) — co-creation, community access, custodian liaison, presentation in Angola.

FUNDING PATH

Mobility grant (≤€4,000) funds the scouting trip; the Visual Arts grant funds collaborative production and a public presentation in Angola and Europe.

THE PRINCIPLE

Made with custodians, not about them — equitable Africa–Europe co-creation, exactly the dialogue the Goethe programme exists to fund.